

Rainbow's End

..A NOVEL.

BY REX BEACH

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"The Iron Trail," "The Spoilers"
"Heart of the Sunset," etc.

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"Don't forget those pearls from the Caribbean, as large as plums," Johnny smiled. "I could never quite swallow that. A pearl the size of a currant would buy our freedom right now." After a moment he went on, more seriously: "I've a notion to look into that old well this very afternoon. I-I dare say I'm foolish, but—somehow the story doesn't sound so improbable as it did. Perhaps it is worth investigating—" He made up his mind swiftly. "I—I'm off this very instant."

When O'Reilly emerged from the hut he found Jacket industriously at work over a fragment of grindstone which he had somewhere unearthed. The boy looked up at his friend's approach and held out for inspection a long, thin file, which he was slowly shaping into a knife-blade.

"What do you think of that?" he queried proudly. "It may come in handy when we are ready to clear out of this pesthole."

"Where did you get it?"

"Oh, I stole it. I steal everything I can lay my hands on nowadays. One can never tell when he may have a throat to cut, and a file has good steel in it."

"Since you are such an accomplished thief, do you think you could steal something for me?" O'Reilly inquired. "A piece of rope?"

"Rope?" Jacket was puzzled. "Rope is only good for hanging Spaniards. My friend in the fish market has a volandra, and—perhaps I can rob him of a balayard." Laying aside his task, Jacket arose and made off in the direction of the water front. He was back within an hour, and under his shirt he carried a coil of worn but serviceable rope. Without waiting to explain his need for this unusual article, O'Reilly linked arms with the boy and set out to climb La Cumbre. When at last they stood in the unused quarry and Johnny made known his intention to explore the old well, Jacket regarded him with undisguised amazement.

"What do you expect to find down there?" the latter inquired.

"To tell you the truth, I don't really expect to find anything," the man confessed. "Now that I'm here, I'm here."



"I'm Going to Have a Look for the Hidden Treasure."

gining to feel silly; nevertheless, I'm going to have a look for the hidden treasure of the Varona."

"Hidden treasure!" From Jacket's expression it was plain that he feared his friend was mildly mad. Even after O'Reilly had told him something about old Don Esteban's missing riches, he scouted the story. He peeped inquisitively into the dark opening of the well, then he shook his head. "Camraba! What an idea! Was this old man crazy, to throw his money away?"

"He—had more than he knew what to do with, and he wished to save it from the Spaniards," O'Reilly explained lamely.

"Humph! Nobody ever had more money than he wanted." The boy's disgust at such credulity was plain. "This well looks just like any other, only deeper; you'd better look out that you don't break your neck like that foolish old woman, that Donna What's-Her-Name."

O'Reilly did indeed feel that he was making himself ridiculous; nevertheless, he made the rope fast and swung himself down out of the sunlight, leaving Jacket to stand guard over him. Perhaps fifteen minutes later he reappeared, panting from his exertions. He was wet, slimy; his clothes were streaked and stained with mud. Jacket began to laugh shrilly at his appearance.

"Ha! What a big lizard is this! Your beautiful garments are spoiled. And the treasure? Where is it?" The lad was delighted. He bent double with mirth; he slapped his bare legs and stamped his feet in glee.

O'Reilly grinned good-naturedly, and replaced the planks which had covered the orifice, then hid the rope in some nearby bushes. On their way back he endured his young friend's

dancer absent-mindedly, but as they neared Asensio's house he started Jacket by saying, "Can you manage to find a pickax or a crowbar?"

Jacket's eyes opened; he stopped in the middle of the dusty road. "What did you see down there, compadre? Tell me."

"Nothing much. Just enough to make me want to see more. Do you think you can steal some sort of a tool for me?"

"I can try."

"Please do. And remember, say nothing before Asensio or his wife." Rosa met O'Reilly just inside the door, and at sight of her he uttered an exclamation of surprise, for during his absence she had removed the stain from her face and discarded that disfigurement which Evangelina had fitted to her back prior to their departure from the Pan de Matanzas. She stood before him now, straight and slim and graceful—the Rosa of his dreams, only very thin, very fragile. Her poor tatters only enhanced her prettiness, so he thought.

"Rosa, dear! Do you think this is quite safe?" he ventured, doubtfully. Evangelina, who was bending over her husband, straightened herself and came forward with a smile upon her black face.

"She is beautiful, eh? Too beautiful to look at? What did I tell you?" Rosa was in delightful confusion at O'Reilly's evident surprise and admiration. "Then I'm not so altogether changed?" she asked.

"Why, you haven't changed at all, except to grow more beautiful. Evangelina is right; you are too beautiful to look at. But wait!" He drew her aside and whispered, "I've been down in the well." Some tremor in his voice, some glint in his eyes, caused the girl to seize him eagerly, fiercely. "I may be wrong," he said hurriedly; "there may be nothing in it—and yet I saw something."

"What?"

"Wooden beams, timbers of some sort, behind the stone curbing." It was plain Rosa did not comprehend, so he hurried on. "At first I noticed nothing unusual, except that the bottom of the well is nearly dry—filled up, you know, with debris and stuff that has fallen in from the curbing above, then I saw that although the well is dug through rock, nevertheless it is entirely curbed up with stones laid in mortar. That struck me as queer."

"Yes?"

"I noticed, too, in one place that there was wood behind—as if timbers had been placed there to cover the entrance to a cave. You know this Cuban rock is full of caverns."

Rosa clasped her hands, she began to tremble. "You have found it, O'Reilly. You have!" she whispered. "No, no, I've found nothing yet. But I've sent Jacket for a pickax or a bar and tonight I'm going to pull down those stones and see what is behind them."

"To night? You must let me go, too. I want to help."

"Very well. But meanwhile you mustn't let your hopes rise too high, for there is every chance that you will be disappointed. And don't mention it to Evangelina. Now, then, I've a few pennies left and I'm going to buy some candles."

Rosa embraced her lover impulsively. "Something tells me it is true! Something tells me you are going to save us all."

Evangelina in the far corner of the hut muttered to her husband: "Such love-birds! They are like parakeets, forever kissing and cooing!"

Jacket returned at dusk, and with him he brought a rusty three-foot iron bar, evidently part of a window grating. The boy was tired, disgusted, and in a vile temper. "A pickax! A crowbar!" he cursed eloquently. "One might as well try to steal a cannon out of San Severino. I'm ready to do anything within reason, but—"

"Why, this will do nicely; it is just what I want," O'Reilly told him.

"Humph! I'm glad to hear it, for that rod was nearly the death of me. I broke my back wrenching at it and the villain who owned the house—may a bad lightning split him!—he ran after me until I nearly expired. If my new knife had been sharp I would have turned and sent him home with it between his ribs. Tomorrow I shall put an edge on it. Believe me, I ran until my lungs burst."

Little food remained in the hut, barely enough for Asensio and the women, and inasmuch as O'Reilly had spent his last centavo for candles he and Jacket were forced to go hungry again. Late that evening, after the wretched prison quarters had grown quiet, the three treasure hunters stole out of their hovel and wound up the hill. In spite of their excitement they went slowly, for none of them had the strength to hurry. Fortunately there were few prowlers within the lines, hunger having robbed the reconnoiters of the spirit to venture forth, and in consequence Spanish vigilance had relaxed; it was now confined to the far-flung girdle of intrenchments which encircled the city. The trio encountered no one.

Leaving Jacket on guard at the crest of the hill, O'Reilly stationed Rosa at the mouth of the well, then lowered himself once more into it. Lighting his candle, he made a careful examination of the place, with the result that Esteban's theory of the missing riches seemed even less improbable than it had earlier in the day. The masonry work, he discovered, had been done with a painstaking thoroughness which spoke of the abundance of slave labor, and time had barely begun to affect it. Here and there a piece of the mortar had loosened and come away, but for the most part it stood as solid as the stones between which it was laid. Shoulder-high to O'Reilly there appeared to be a section of the curbing less smoothly fitted than the rest, and through an interstice in this he detected what seemed to be a damp wooden beam. At this point he brought his iron bar into play.

It was not long before he discovered that his work was cut out for him. The cement was like flint and his blunt makeshift implement was almost useless against it. Ankle-deep in the muddy water, he patiently pecked and pounded and chipped, endeavoring to enlarge the crevice so as to use his bar as a lever. The sweat streamed from him and he became dismayed at



"It Begins to Look as If There Really Was a Bulkhead."

breathing spells he could discern her white face dimly illumined by the candle light from below.

After he had worked for an hour or two, he made a report: "It begins to look as if there really was a bulkhead or a door in there."

The girl clasped her hands and laughed with delight. "Do hurry, dear! I'm dying of suspense."

O'Reilly groaned: "That fellow, Sebastian, knew his business. This cement is like steel, and I'm afraid of breaking my crowbar."

Rosa found a leaf, folded a kiss into it, and dropped it to him. "That will give you strength," she declared. O'Reilly lost all count of time after a while and he was incredulous when Jacket came to warn him that daylight was less than an hour away. "Why, I haven't started!" he protested. He discovered, much to his surprise, that he was ready to drop from fatigue and that his hands were torn and blistered; when he had climbed the rope to the upper air he felt exhausted in the deep grass. "I—I'm not myself at all," he apologized; "nothing to eat, you know. But the work will go faster now, for I've made a beginning."

"Do you still think—Rosa hesitated to voice the question which trembled on her lips."

"I'll know for sure tonight." He directed Jacket to replace the planks over the well; then the three of them stole away.

O'Reilly spent most of that day in a profound stupor of exhaustion, while Rosa watched anxiously over him. Jacket, it seemed, had peacefully slumbered on picket duty, so he occupied himself by grinding away at his knife. The last scraps of food disappeared that evening.

When night fell and it came time to return to the top of La Cumbre, O'Reilly asked himself if his strength would prove sufficient for the task in hand. He was spiritless, sore, weak; he ached in every bone and muscle, and it required all his determination to propel himself up the hill. He wondered if he were wise thus to sacrifice his waning energies on a hope so forlorn as this, but by now he had begun to more than half believe in the existence of the Varona treasure and he felt an almost irresistible curiosity to learn what secret, if any, was concealed behind those water-soaked timbers at the bottom of the well. He realized, of course, that every hour he remained here, now that food and money were gone, lessened the chances of escape; but, on the other hand, he reasoned, with equal force, that if he had indeed stumbled upon the missing hoard salvation for all of them was assured. The stake, it seemed to him, was worth the hazard.

Given tempered tools to work with, it would have been no great undertaking to tear down that cemented wall of stones, but armed with nothing except his bare hands and that soft iron bar, O'Reilly spent nearly the whole night at his task. Long before the last rock had yielded, however, he beheld that which caused him to turn a strained face upward to Rosa.

"There's a little door, as sure as you live," he told her.

The girl was beside herself with excitement. "Yes? What else? What more do you see?"

"Nothing. It appears to be made of solid timbers, and has two huge hand-wrought locks."

"Locks! Then we have found it." Rosa closed her eyes; she swayed momentarily. "Esteban was right. Locks, indeed! That means something to hide. Oh, if I could only help you!"

"Heavens! If I only had something—anything to work with!" muttered the American as he felt to with redoubled energy. He no longer tried to conserve his strength, for the treasure seeker's lust beset him. Rosa looked on, wringing her hands and urging him to greater haste.

But the low, thick door was built of some hard, native wood: it was wet and tough and slippery. O'Reilly's blows made no impression upon it, nor upon the heavy hasps and staples with which it was secured in place. The latter were deeply rusted, to be sure, but they withstood his efforts, and he was finally forced to rest, baffled, enraged, half hysterical from weakness and fatigue.

Daylight was at hand once more, but he refused to give up, and worked on stubbornly, furiously, until Rosa, in an agony, besought him to desist. Johnny again collapsed on the grass and lay panting while the other two replaced the planks.

"Another hour and I'd have been into it," he declared, huskily.

"You will kill yourself," Jacket told him.

Rosa bent over him with shining eyes and parted lips. "Yes," said she. "Be patient. We will come back, O'Reilly, and tonight we shall be rich."

Colonel Cobo lit a black cigarette, leaned back in his chair, and exhaled two fierce jets of smoke through his nostrils. For a full moment he scowled forbiddingly at the sergeant who had asked to see him.

"What's this you are telling me?" he inquired finally.

The sergeant, a mean-faced, low-browed man, stirred uneasily. "It is God's truth. There are spirits on La Cumbre, and I wish to see the priest about it."

"Spirits? What kind of spirits?"

The fellow shrugged. "Evil spirits—spirits from hell. The men are buying charms."

"Bah! I took you to be a sensible person."

"You don't believe me? Well, I didn't believe them, when they told me about it. But I saw with my own eyes."

Cobo leaned forward, mildly astonished. Of all his villainous troop, this man was the last one he had credited with imagination of this sort. "What did you see?"

"A ghost, my colonel, nothing else. La Cumbre is no place for an honest Christian."

The colonel burst into a mocking laugh. "An honest Christian! You! Of all my vile ruffians, you are the vilest. Why, you're a thief, a liar, and an assassin! You are lying to me now. Come—the truth for once, before I give you the compote."

"As God is my judge, I'm telling you the truth," protested the soldier. "Flog me if you will—rather the compote than another night in those trenches. You know that old quinta?"

"Where Pancho Cuto made a goat of himself? Perfectly. Do you mean to say that you saw old Esteban Varona walking with his head in his hands?"

"No, but I saw that she-devil who fell in the well and broke her neck."

"Eh? When did you behold this—this marvel?"

"Two nights ago. She was there beside the well and her face shone through the night like a lantern. There was fire upon it. She came and went, like a moth in the lamplight. I tell you I repented of my sins. Some of the men laughed at me when I told them, as they had laughed at the others. But last night two of the doubters went up there."

"Exactly. And they saw nothing." "Your pardon, my colonel. They came back in a cold sweat, and they spent the night on their knees. The woman was there again. You have seen the salt sea at night? Well, her face was aglow, like that, so they said. They heard the clanking of chains, too, and the sound of hammers, coming from the very bowels of the earth. It is all plain enough, when you know the story. But it is terrifying."

"This is indeed amazing," Cobo acknowledged, "but of course there is some simple explanation. Spirits, if indeed there are such things, are made of nothing—they are like thin air. How, then, could they rattle chains? You probably saw some wretched pacifists in search of food and imagined the rest."

"Indeed! Then what did I hear with these very ears? Whispers, murmurs, groans, and the clinkety-clink of old Sebastian's chain. For his sins that old slave is chained in some cavern of the mountain. Soundless! I'm no baby! I know when I'm asleep, and I know when I'm awake. That place is accursed, and I want no more of it."

Cobo fell into frowning meditation, allowing his cigarette to smolder down until it burned his thick fingers. He was not a superstitious man and he put no faith in the supernatural, nevertheless he was convinced that his sergeant was not lying, and reference to Pancho Cuto had set his mind to working along strange channels. He had known Cuto well, and the latter's stubborn belief in the existence of that Varona treasure had more than once impressed him. He wondered now if others shared that faith, or if by chance they had discovered a clue to the whereabouts of the money and were conducting a secret search. It was a fantastic idea, nevertheless.

Cobo told himself that if people were prying about those deserted premises it was with some object, and their actions would warrant observation. The presence of the woman—a woman—with the glow of phosphorus upon her face was puzzling, but the whole affair was puzzling. He determined to investigate. After a time he murmured, "I should like to see this spirit."

The sergeant shrugged. It was plain from his expression that he could not account for such a desire. "Another night is coming," said he.

"Good! I shall visit the place, and if I see anything unusual I—well, I shall believe what you have told me. Meanwhile, go see your priest by all means. It will do you no harm."

NO AUTHORITY GIVEN TO MOVE AIRPLANE BASE

PORTLAND, Aug. 28.—No authorization had been made for moving the forest fire airplane base from Roseburg to Eugene, according to a telegram from Senator McNary received late Wednesday afternoon, which follows:

"To Carl E. Wimberly: Colonel Pratt, executive officer for major general, advises me that in accordance with a promise previously given, he had wired the department of air service at San Francisco to maintain the bases at Salem and Roseburg. Colonel Pratt does not understand the cause for changing the base which you report. He is wiring Colonel Arnold, western department of the air service, to find out the reason for the change. Unless an important reason is advanced, stations will be maintained at Salem and Roseburg as before. Charles L. McNary, United States senator."

Two thousand three hundred silk worms are necessary to produce two pounds of silk.

Another Portland Show

September 15th, the date of President Wilson's proposed visit to Oregon, will be one in which every section of the state will feel a deep interest, and Portland will be the shrine for those desiring to meet and hear the President.

The reception of the president is a state and not a city function. However, a perusal of the names of the members of the committee would give the impression that the affair was purely local, with those in charge having no acquaintance in the state outside of one or two subdivisions in the Rose City.

The committee did observe the propriety of appointing Governor Olcott and Mayor Baker as committeemen. State institutions and organizations are conspicuous by their absence.

It would be natural to suppose that the state grange, state bankers association, state hotel keepers, as well as the state chamber of commerce, would be honored by having a representative on the list. The state press outside of Portland has been entirely ignored. Albany, Astoria, Baker, Eugene, Pendleton and Salem have Democratic newspapers of power and influence, whose work in and out of season entitle their editors to recognition. They have been absolutely ignored, and the press will be represented by C. S. Jackson of the Journal and Edgar B. Piper of the Oregonian. The latter evidently owes his selection to the committee to his yeoman service in behalf of the league of nations.

Whoever have been in charge of the arrangements has demonstrated their ability to blunder, and to justify the criticism so often made by the smaller cities and towns that when questions affecting the entire state are at issue, Portland wants to be the whole show.

First Flier to Reach New York in Race from Toronto to New York



Sergeant C. B. Coombs

Making 221 miles in 211 minutes flying time, Sergeant C. B. Coombs was the first aviator to fly from Toronto to New York in the international race between those two cities. This photograph was taken just before he started his return trip to the Canadian city.

UNION MEN CONCEDE TO WISHES OF PRESIDENT

WASHINGTON, Aug. 30.—Having prevailed upon the union leaders in a conference yesterday to postpone the calling of strikes in the plants of the United States Steel Corporation, President Wilson now contemplates an appeal to employers generally to make concessions to labor.

Following up his proposal for a truce between capital and labor as the prerequisite of the restoration of normal production conditions, and reduction of the high cost of living, the president is expected to issue an address on or about Labor day which will call the attention of employers to their duty to the nation in this crisis, just as his statement to the railroad shompen argued organized labor generally to abandon their demands for wage advances.

PERSHING IS GIVEN PERMANENT RANK IN HONOR OF SERVICE

WASHINGTON, Aug. 28.—In recognition of General John J. Pershing's services in the war, the house today passed a bill authorizing the president to confer on him the permanent rank of general. The measure now goes to the senate.

LEGION HEAD ACQUITTED.

Astoria, Aug. 28.—Jesse R. Hinman, president of Clatsop post, American legion, was acquitted at his police court trial this afternoon of "using abusive language."

CONSTITUTION DAY OBSERVANCE URGED UPON OREGONIANS

SALEM, Sept. 3.—The people of Oregon are urged by Governor Olcott to join with the people of the other states in a general celebration and observance of "Constitution day" on Wednesday, September 17.

The observance of this day is being agitated throughout the United States by the National Securities league, of which Mrs. Robert S. Murphy of Eugene, is director for Oregon. In an open letter addressed to the people of Oregon today, the governor says:

"It appeals to me as peculiarly fitting that following the cessation of the great war in which our nation played such a prominent and glorious part, that we should pause on this one day of the year at least to pay some tribute to the memory of our fathers who gave us such a priceless heritage in that document which has largely transmitted to us the liberties and prosperity which we now enjoy."

"Many nations are menaced by or are passing through, the throes of anarchy, disorder and lawlessness. I am firm in the belief that the great rank and file of the American people are too patriotic, too level headed and too sensible of the blessings that they enjoy under our glorious constitution to be led astray by the false doctrines of propagandists."

"I trust that the people of Oregon will on Wednesday, September 17, 1919, give due remembrance to the anniversary of the birth of our constitution—the foundation and support of our national greatness."

OLD SAILOR GOES TO SEA ALONE IN YAWL; GOLDEN GATE IS GOAL

SEATTLE, Sept. 2.—Coast guards and state authorities in practically every port on the American side of the Straits of Juan de Fuca today are watching for a little boat with a leg-of-mutton sail, headed for the open sea and with San Francisco as its intended destination.

Aboard the frail craft is Chief Master Arns Henry Torentson, an elderly seafarer of Bremerton, once retired from the navy after 39 years of service, but recalled again when the United States entered the war.

Placed on the retired list again last Saturday, Torentson, who is 56 years old, provisioned the yawl and at 9 o'clock Sunday morning set sail for San Francisco.

His wife, reporting the facts to the sheriff's office Monday, declared her belief that he is mentally unbalanced. Because of his advanced years and without aid in navigation while he gets needed sleep, no hope is entertained for him once he passes Cape Flattery.

GERMAN DYES TO COME IN

WASHINGTON, Sept. 2.—Importation of a six months' supply of dyes from Germany for American manufacturers will be allowed under a ruling announced today by the war trade board.

Manufacturers have been requested to file statements with the board showing the total quantities of dyes needed for the six months period beginning October 1.

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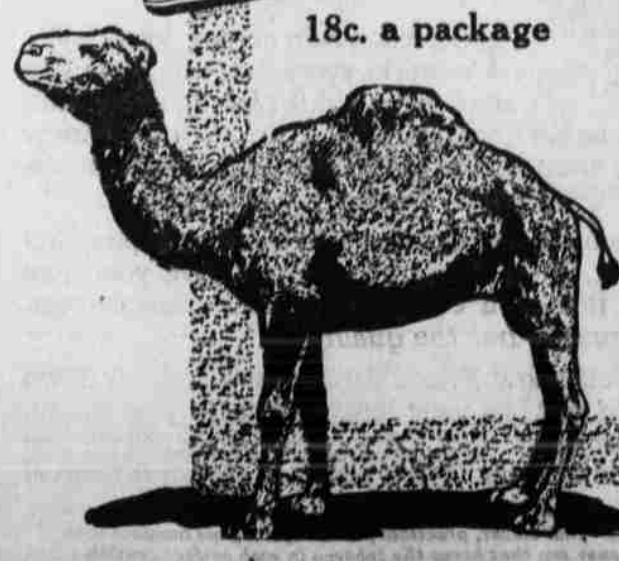
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